



Nationalism, leaders, and four forms of terrorist groups

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ABSTRACT

Whether political leaders playing the nationalist card to enhance their legitimacy provoke the activity of terrorist groups is an important yet underexplored question. I argue that there is a positive association between nationalist leaders and certain types of terrorist groups, depending on the ideology of the group. My analysis focuses on four specific group ideologies: ethnonationalist, left-wing, right-wing, and religious fundamentalist. Specifically, I conceptualize that: 1) nationalist leaders amplify the activity of ethnonationalist terrorist groups that advocate for the interests of ethnic others, 2) nationalist politics diminish the activity of left-wing groups primarily focused on addressing economic inequality, 3) nationalist leaders empower right-wing groups that target perceived outgroup members, and 4) nationalist politics increase the activity of religious fundamentalist groups that resist persecution based on their beliefs. The empirical findings indicate some deviations from these expectations. Nationalistic leadership is a significant driver of activity among ethnonationalist and religious fundamentalist terrorist groups, reduces the engagement of left-wing groups, and has minimal impact on right-wing groups. Overall, this analysis suggests that nationalist leaders present a security risk, as their actions likely incite, rather than mitigate, the activities of specific terrorist groups.

KEYWORDS

Nationalism; nationalist leaders; ethnonationalist; left-wing; right-wing; and religious fundamentalist terrorist groups

Before taking office, political leaders around the world must recite an oath of office. For instance, in the U.S., the president-elect promises, 'I do solemnly swear (or affirm) that I will faithfully execute the Office of President of the United States, and will to the best of my ability, preserve, protect, and defend the Constitution of the United States' (Article II, Section I, Clause 8 of the U.S. Constitution). A head of state's primary responsibility is to ensure the nation's and its citizens' safety from anti-government groups. However, it is not always clear whether all heads of state have fulfilled this duty during their tenures. In the U.S., while George W. Bush focused on preventing global terrorism, Donald Trump may have inadvertently encouraged and empowered right-wing terrorist groups.¹ Political leaders in other countries, such as China, India, and Turkey, face similar challenges and policy implications. This raises an important question: Why have some world leaders succeeded in countering terrorism while others have exacerbated it? By examining the

nationalist tendencies of state leaders in relation to different types of terrorist groups,² I address this significant but often overlooked question.

This study is highly relevant in today's security landscape, as it can help develop effective anti-terrorism strategies to prevent violent extremism. As the old saying goes, 'prevention is better than cure.' If left unaddressed, terrorist groups can recruit more individuals who feel oppressed, creating a stronger collective force. However, existing research has been limited in explaining the relationship between nationalism and terrorism,³ often due to "the 'silo' problem in the field where '[nationalism], 'terror(ism),' 'state repression,' 'non-violent protest,' and other 'forms' of political conflict are studied in isolation" (Moore 2017, 58). And also, as Wimmer (2023, 817) points out, 'while we may have exhausted the interest in the origins of nationalism, we are just beginning to understand nationalism's variegated consequences' (see Choi 2025 for a more comprehensive review). By bridging nationalism and terrorism studies, I conduct a first-cut analysis of how nationalist leaders impact the various activities of terrorist groups.

As nationalism emerges as a potent global force, its connection to contemporary terrorism has become increasingly evident.⁴ For example, in the 2021 National Strategy for Countering Domestic Terrorism, President Joseph Biden highlighted that white nationalism represents the most significant threat to the United States.⁵ Drawing on Gellner's (1983) definition of nationalism as 'primarily a political principle, which holds that the political and the national unit should be congruent,' I define nationalist leaders as those who utilize ethnoreligious nationalism to garner political support.⁶ It is important to note that nationalist leaders span a broad spectrum of the political landscape, including figures such as Donald Trump, Narendra Modi, Viktor Orbán, Recep Erdoğan, Vladimir Putin, and Xi Jinping.⁷ This observation aligns with Freeden's (1998) insights that nationalism often operates alongside other ideologies, including liberalism, social democracy, conservatism, and fascism. When nationalist leaders push for ethnoreligious homogenization within their territories, they frequently resort to political violence, such as forcibly assimilating, exploiting, expelling, or even killing non-national groups. These violent actions create both internal and external security risks. One of these risks is the potential incitement of terrorist activity, where ethnoreligious minorities (or even the majority) form terrorist groups to address grievances and carry out attacks against the nationalist regime. Notable examples include the Palestinian struggle against the Israeli government, the Chechen resistance to the Russian government, the Tamil Tigers against the Sinhalese government, the Basque separatist efforts against the Spanish government, and the Sunni opposition to the Syrian government.

This study departs from previous research that treats terrorism as a homogeneous political phenomenon (e.g. Klein 2021; Piazza 2006; Young 2019) or focuses on a single type of terrorism (e.g. Choi 2022; Quadghiri and Peillex 2018). I underscore that terrorism is a heterogeneous phenomenon, meaning it is not uniform and can vary based on the ideologies of the groups involved. This distinction is essential for understanding whether nationalist leaders instigate specific types of terrorist groups; this becomes challenging without differentiating among heterogeneous terrorist groups.

In this study, I classify terrorist groups according to their ideologies. As Crenshaw (1988, 15) points out, the ideological orientation of terrorist groups is significant and should be considered a crucial factor in understanding their intentions. Similarly, Drake (1998, 78) argues that 'it is [an] ideology that provides terrorists with the moral and political vision

that inspires their violence.’ Therefore, I categorize terrorist groups into four ideological categories: ethnonationalist, left-wing, right-wing, and religious fundamentalist. This classification allows me to better connect the nationalist politics of state leaders to the specific ideologies of the terrorist groups.

I argue that terrorist groups respond differently to nationalist leaders based on their political objectives. My focus is on four key consequences of having nationalist leaders:

- (1) Nationalist leaders are more likely to incite activity from ethnonationalist terrorist groups compared to their non-nationalist counterparts.
- (2) Nationalist politics tend to have a negative association with left-wing group activity.
- (3) Nationalist leaders are more likely to provoke right-wing group activity than non-nationalist leaders.
- (4) Nationalist politics are positively associated with religious fundamentalist group activity compared to non-nationalist politics.

To test these hypotheses, I compile a sample of 726 terrorist groups across 100 countries from 1970 to 2016. The empirical results slightly deviate from my expectations. Specifically, nationalist leaders a) significantly and positively drive the activities of ethnonationalist and religious fundamentalist terrorist groups, b) reduce the activities of left-wing groups, and c) have no impact on right-wing terrorist groups. These findings present a challenging scenario for the counterterrorism community in their efforts to deter terrorism, as nationalist leadership tends to incite increased terrorist activity by prioritizing ethnonationalism over the rights of ethnic others.

In the next section, I discuss the struggle between nationalist leaders and terrorist groups regarding the processes of legitimization and delegitimization. Following that, I explore the conceptual connections between nationalism and each of the four types of terrorist groups. Afterward, I explain the statistical model used in the study, detail how the variables were measured, and describe the data collection process. I then evaluate the empirical results. The concluding section summarizes the key findings and outlines their policy implications.

Legitimization versus delegitimization

Conflict arises when nationalist leaders and terrorist groups assert their right to govern a nation (Hurd 2010; Sprinzak 1995). Nationalist leaders often leverage nationalism to legitimize their power, favoring their own ethnic group while discriminating against others. In response, terrorist groups oppose these discriminatory policies and take collective action to challenge the authority of nationalist leaders. For example, when Bosnian leaders called for the unification of their people, a terrorist group made up of Bosnian Serbs accused those leaders of committing ethnically motivated violence against their group (Gagnon 2006; Sekulić, Massey, and Hodson 2006).

To address a crisis of legitimacy, state leaders often attempt to align the nation with the state. They may use nationalist rhetoric against ethnic groups perceived as ‘others.’ This strategy involves rallying support from their own ethnic group at the expense of others, creating a divide between ‘us’ and ‘them.’ This can lead to ethnic favoritism toward ‘us’

and discrimination against ‘them’ (Barker 2001, 61). The successful implementation of this approach can result in the formation of an ethnically homogeneous nation, which in turn legitimizes political authority. Nationalism is crucial to this process, as it serves as ‘a theory of political legitimacy’ (Gellner 1983, 1) and is considered ‘the most potent source of state legitimacy’ (Malëšević 2006, 6). A recent example of this can be seen in Syria, where Bashar al-Assad sought to create a pure, unified society composed of loyal followers from his ethnic group, the Alawites, who represent only 11 percent of the country’s population. Al-Assad’s comments on the ongoing internal conflict emphasized this point: ‘We lost many of our youth and infrastructure, but we gained a healthier and more homogenous society’ (Elba 2017, emphasis added). Conversely, when state leaders lose political legitimacy, they may face opposition that challenges their vision and ideas, potentially leading to legislative deadlock, armed rebellions, and even regime collapse (Dahl 1971).

When individuals become frustrated and angry with nationalist leaders, they often need to channel their outrage into collective action, whether peaceful protests or violence (see Blagojevic 2009; Williams 1994). To do this, oppressed individuals may recall the childhood fable by Aesop, which states, ‘sticks in a bundle can’t be broken, but sticks taken singly can be easily broken.’ This emphasizes the power of unity. However, when peaceful means of conflict resolution have been exhausted (Blagojevic 2009; Williams 1994), some aggrieved individuals may turn to terrorism. By forming a united terrorist group, they can create a more powerful representation of themselves and achieve what they cannot accomplish individually. If members of a terrorist group effectively mobilize collective action against nationalist leaders, they can achieve goals that unorganized individuals cannot. In this process, terrorist groups become collective organizations capable of seriously challenging the political legitimacy of a nationalist leader through political violence. Accordingly, terrorism can be seen as ‘the peak of the process of delegitimization’ (Sprinzak 1995, 18).

Although a terrorist group may strive to achieve its political objectives, individuals without such an organization are unlikely to influence a nationalist leader’s ‘monopoly of the legitimate use of violence’ due to collective action problems (Gerth and Mills 1946, 78; Olson 1965). Unorganized individuals remain self-interested, disconnected, and powerless. They lack the necessary mobilization power to express their demands effectively. Few individuals are likely to participate in risky, violent actions, while many prefer a free ride. Furthermore, those who aspire to engage in terrorist activities must overcome not only the free-rider problem but also significant obstacles such as securing financial support and weapons. Executing terrorist plots is challenging without easy access to essential resources like meals, transportation, and armaments (Kis-Katos, Liebert, and Schulze 2014). However, if these aggrieved individuals can organize into groups, they can collectively question the regime’s legitimacy by resorting to a political tool that is otherwise unavailable to them: illegitimate, unconventional violence.

Terrorist groups are diverse in their forms and motivations, driven by various ideologies that shape their actions (see Asal and Rethemeyer 2008; Cronin [2002] 2003; Gaibulloev and Sandler 2021; S. Jones and Libicki 2008; Rapoport 2004). For example, ethnonationalist groups seek independence, territorial control, or autonomy from the current government or colonial powers, as demonstrated by Algeria’s National Liberation Front (FLN) in its campaign against France. Left-wing terrorist groups may adhere to Marxist-Leninist or Maoist ideologies and aim to establish

socialist states, as seen with Italy's Red Brigades and Peru's Shining Path. Some left-wing groups advocate for liberal goals, such as environmental and animal rights. Right-wing terrorist groups emerged after World War I, fueled by economic turmoil between 1890 and 1945. These groups promote ultra-conservative policies and target those they perceive as undesirable or inferior, such as the Ku Klux Klan. Religious fundamentalist terrorist groups gained traction following the Iranian Revolution and the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in 1979. They commit acts of terrorism to fulfill a religious mandate or coerce others into adherence, often challenging governments that impose religious beliefs and practices on the population. A notable example is the Taliban regime in Afghanistan during the U.S. occupation.

It is essential to analyze how the nationalist politics of state leaders can increase specific terrorist activities, considering these groups' diverse ideologies and objectives.

Nationalist leaders and ethnonationalist terrorist groups

I argue that the nationalist politics of state leaders likely contributes to the emergence of ethnonationalist terrorist groups. This argument highlights the competition for political legitimacy between state leaders and these groups. When state leaders bolster their authority through nationalism, they often prioritize their own ethnic group, while marginalizing others by denying them access to economic resources, public services, and political power (Atran 1990; Brass 1991; Piazza 2012; Wimmer 2013). Such discrimination can foster frustration and anger, which may escalate into terrorism. Byman (1998, 156) notes that nationalist discrimination – be it economic, political, or cultural – can provoke significant resentment and lead to ethnic terrorism. Notable examples of ethnonationalist terrorist groups that arose in response to nationalist state leaders include ETA (Basque Homeland and Liberty) in Spain, the Free Papua Movement in Indonesia, and Al-Fatah in the Israeli Occupied Territories (up until 1988) (De la Calle 2015).

Nationalist leaders often create a sense of an 'us versus them' mentality by favoring members of their nation-state's 'in-group' over 'out-group' members (Asal and Rethemeyer 2008; Mylonas and Kuo 2018; Tajfel 1982). This approach aligns with Schmitt's (1976) view that sovereignty is fundamentally about distinguishing between friends and enemies. Such nationalist politics can easily exacerbate political hostility between ethnic groups, as 'very little nationalist rabble-rousing or nationalistic combativeness is required to generate dangerous situations' (Posen 1993, 29). This dynamic is more likely to occur in the context of deep-seated, traumatic memories of past violence (Brass 1991; Horowitz 2001; Sambanis 2001; Sekulić, Massey, and Hodson 2006; Snyder 2000; S. Wilkinson 2004).

Nationalist leaders who abuse, persecute, or kill members of ethnic minorities are likely to provoke these groups into taking up arms in self-defense. Several studies support this argument. Wimmer (2013) explains that when ethnic groups are excluded from the government, they may begin with peaceful protests, which can eventually escalate into armed rebellion. Cederman, Gleditsch, and Buhaug (2013) and Wimmer, Cederman, and Min (2009) maintain that the exclusion of ethnic minorities from central government increases the risk of armed conflict. Asal et al. (2016) find that excluding an ethnic group from national politics significantly contributes to ethnic strife. Van Evera (1994, 9) argues that the more minorities are oppressed by nationalist leaders, the greater the risk of war.

Spain serves as a case in point. In 1959, Basque separatists founded ETA to oppose Francisco Franco's pro-Spanish nationalism, which aimed to impose a singular national identity by repressing other cultures in Spain. Franco sought to create a political community defined solely by Spaniards, explicitly rejecting other ethnic identities. He particularly victimized the Basques, attempting to erase their culture, language, and history under the guise of uniting Spain (Minder 2018; J. Sullivan 1988). In response to the threat against Basque identity, a group of college students formed ETA and carried out a series of terrorist attacks against the Spanish government. According to Bereciartu (2006, 82), 'it was precisely Francoism, with its repressive violence, which provoked ETA into the choice of violent methods of struggle.' One of ETA's primary tactics was the assassination of high-ranking Spanish military officers, judges, and government officials seen as key proponents of Spanish nationalism. ETA's ultimate aim was establishing an independent Basque homeland (Barros 2003). Until its disarmament in May 2018, ETA continued to recruit members disillusioned by Spanish nationalism, ultimately killing over 800 people.

This discussion leads to the following hypothesis:

H1: Compared to their non-nationalist counterparts, nationalist leaders are more likely to incite the activity of ethnonationalist terrorist groups, which are composed of marginalized ethnic others.

Nationalist leaders and right-wing terrorist groups

Leaders who promote nationalist politics often encourage the activities of right-wing terrorist groups, as both typically share similar political agendas. Right-wing terrorist groups, such as the American Ku Klux Klan, capitalize on racial identity, which usually stems from the ethnic majority within a country. They seek national dominance and ethnic purity (Kis-Katos, Liebert, and Schulze 2014). These groups perceive political and economic insecurity, along with threats from other ethnic communities, religious groups, classes deemed undesirable, and so-called 'inferior' races. In response, they launch private wars targeting Jews, Arabs, Catholics, Blacks, Communists, homosexuals, foreign workers, and other 'inferiors,' whom they believe are receiving more than they deserve. Unlike ethnonationalist or left-wing terrorist groups, which often engage in direct confrontations with the current government, many right-wing terrorist groups view the conflict with the regime as secondary. They do not typically see the government as their primary opponent; instead, they often expect it to either cooperate with them or at least remain uninvolved (Piazza 2017; Sprinzak 1995; see also Asal and Rethemeyer 2008; Cronin [2002] 2003; S. Jones and Libicki 2008; Rapoport 2004). This lack of opposition is unsurprising, as many right-wing terrorist groups and nationalist leaders share a similar worldview and rarely challenge each other's legitimacy. This shared perspective helps differentiate right-wing from left-wing terrorist groups.

Nationalist leaders often support and empower right-wing terrorist groups because they share similar political agendas. Both groups tend to promote ethnocentrism, the belief that ethnicity is a significant organizing principle in society and that other ethnicities are intellectually and culturally inferior (Atran 1990; Brass 1991; Byman 1998; Piazza 2017; Sprinzak 1995). Nationalist leaders and right-wing terrorist groups

work to undermine ethnic minorities and, when possible, remove them from the political landscape. This dynamic creates an environment where right-wing terrorist activity can thrive. When nationalist leaders target ethnic minorities, they foster conditions that enable right-wing groups to gain official support, political endorsement, or even tacit approval. Conversely, when nationalist leaders promote equality under the law, they often come into conflict with right-wing terrorist groups. Such ideals challenge these groups, as they seek to establish ethnic privileges for certain groups while opposing equal treatment for all. Consequently, their actions attract greater scrutiny.

The case of the American Ku Klux Klan (KKK) illustrates such a close relationship between nationalist leaders and right-wing terrorist groups. In the aftermath of the Confederacy's defeat in the Civil War, the KKK was formed in 1865. It aimed to control the dramatically changed social situation and to restore white supremacy through extrajudicial means. Its key operations involved a small group of masked and hooded night raiders targeting black individuals suspected of violating white social values. Over the years, the KKK has continued to live by its anti-Black platform, which has been expanded to include anti-Semitism, anti-Catholicism, anti-Communism, and the idea of ethnoreligious American purity. The Vietnam War, the perception of an imminent communist threat, and the inflows of illegal immigrants have been responsible for the repeated ascensions of the militant wings of the KKK. Yet, it should be noted that despite declared enmity against Washington, the KKK seldom attacked the Federal government or its agents directly over the years (Bartoletti 2014; Sprinzak 1995).

The arrival of nationalist President Donald Trump reinvigorated the activity of the KKK, which has sought more significant publicity by advancing its racist agenda (Sanchez 2018). Because the KKK is not necessarily an anti-government movement, it did not have the incentive to terrorize the Trump government. Instead, it felt encouraged or empowered to engage in terrorism against other races and immigrants that they perceived to be inferior (Dugan and Chenoweth 2020). As noted by Berger (2016) and Fisher, Dugan, and Chenoweth (2019), Trump's nationalist rhetoric on immigration and criminal justice effectively rallied white supremacists while disenfranchising minority groups. Trump's online activities openly communicated his allegiance to the far right. After analyzing white nationalist blogs and websites, Berger (2016, 2) states that far-right terrorist groups believed that they were 'receiving clear and frequent signals of support' via Trump's Twitter/X feed (see also Fortunato et al. 2022). With the end of Trump's first tenure, 'top law enforcement officials say the biggest domestic terror threat comes from white supremacists' (E. Sullivan and Benner 2021).

In sum, right-wing terrorist groups become active not because nationalist leaders actively pursue them, but because they receive at least implicit support from these leaders. Both right-wing groups and nationalist leaders share a common enemy and aim to target ethnic others.

This discussion leads to the following hypothesis:

H2: Nationalist leaders are more likely than non-nationalist leaders to encourage the activities of right-wing terrorist groups whose political ideology is ethnocentric.

Nationalist leaders and left-wing terrorist groups⁸

Nationalist state leaders often appeal to nationalism to strengthen their power. However, they are unlikely to discriminate against the political left for regime consolidation. This is because nationalist leaders are more interested in targeting specific ethnic groups (e.g. Sri Lankan Tamils or Rohingya Muslims) rather than focusing on political beliefs (e.g. Marxists, Leninists, or Maoists). When nationalist leaders emphasize ethnic identity as a crucial issue, they typically criticize individuals from disfavored ethnic groups who firmly commit to their cause and maintain highly favorable attitudes and group-supportive beliefs (Devos and Banaji 2005, 448). On the other hand, nationalist leaders are less likely to target and create conflict with the political left, as they tend to be indifferent to the left's main agenda of promoting revolutionary and anti-materialistic activities, regardless of ethnic identity. Therefore, nationalist politics are less likely to provoke action from left-wing terrorist groups.

Left-wing terrorist groups aim to address the unequal distribution of wealth, income, and economic opportunities in their countries, primarily favoring the working class. They view capitalism as their primary target and do not claim to represent a specific ethnic group. Historically, these groups have sought to transform capitalist states into socialist ones through proletarian revolutions. For example, Fidel Castro and Pol Pot initiated their revolutions using terrorist tactics against their respective regimes. However, once in power, these leaders did not focus on dismantling previous nationalist policies. Instead, they implemented a high degree of centralized control through political repression, atheism, collectivization, and forced labor (Albert and Hahnel 1981). Given that these measures were unrelated to the nationalist politics of state leaders, it is difficult to assert that the actions of left-wing terrorist groups were a reaction to nationalist leaders.

Marxism-Leninism and Maoism, the core political ideologies of left-wing terrorist groups, emerged in the 19th and 20th centuries. The success of the Bolshevik Revolution led the Soviet Union (USSR) to adopt Marxist-Leninist doctrines, inspiring various left-wing terrorist groups during the Cold War. However, the collapse of the USSR in 1989 led to a dramatic decline in the activity of left-wing terrorist groups. It is important to note that not all left-wing terrorist groups aligned with the Soviet bloc during 1989-1990 (Harmon 2010). Several left-wing terrorist groups outside Europe and the former USSR region remain active today.

Left-wing terrorism poses a significant threat in various parts of the world. One notable example is the Naxalites, a terrorist group that claims to be the successor of the Communist Party of India (Marxist). This group currently controls regions in central-eastern India and is named after the village of Naxalbari in West Bengal, where a peasant revolt occurred in 1967. This revolt led to the establishment of the Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) two years later. The uprising aimed to redistribute land to the landless and overthrow the upper classes' government through force (Sen 1982). This example illustrates that the nationalist politics of state leaders do not always discourage left-wing terrorism. Other instances include the Communist Party of Nepal-Maoist (CPN-M), which asserts, 'Let us march ahead on the path of struggle toward establishing the people's rule by wrecking the reactionary ruling system of the state.' Additionally, the Maoist militant group Shining Path in Peru seeks to dismantle existing Peruvian institutions in favor of a communist peasant revolutionary regime. In Colombia,

the Ejército de Liberación Nacional combines Marxism-Leninism with liberation theology to address income inequality (Avilés 2012).

This discussion leads to the following hypothesis:

H3: Nationalist leaders are negatively associated with the activities of left-wing terrorist groups whose primary goal is to redistribute economic wealth.

Nationalist leaders and religious fundamentalist terrorist groups

When nationalist leaders restrict the rights of religious minorities, it often leads to a rise in the strength of religious fundamentalist terrorist groups, such as Hamas. This argument posits that a struggle for religious legitimacy can emerge between nationalist leaders and these terrorist groups. When religious individuals face intolerance and persecution, they may resort to terrorism as a means of defending their religious identity. These individuals often interpret religious scriptures in a way that justifies their violent actions or serves as a means to recruit new members (Cromartie 2005). In such situations, terrorist attacks can occur between followers of different religions, such as Muslims targeting Hindus or Christians. Additionally, as sectarianism becomes more entrenched over time, terrorist groups might also turn against different factions within their own religion. For instance, if Shia leaders assume power and implement nationalist rhetoric that undermines the beliefs of Sunnis – and vice versa, as seen in the case of Bashar al-Assad – Sunnis may resort to terrorist violence to retaliate.

In recent decades, Islamist terrorist groups have emerged as the most aggressive subnational actors against nationalist leaders who legitimize their power by promoting Western values and religions in traditionally Muslim societies (Choi and Brown 2022; Kis-Katos, Liebert, and Schulze 2014). Major Islamist terrorist groups, including Hamas, Hezbollah, Al-Qaeda, and ISIS, attempt to delegitimize nationalist leaders by propagating the idea that ‘Islam and the West are culturally incompatible and cannot coexist within the same geographic space’ (Masters 2008, 398). To undermine the legitimacy of nationalist leaders and promote the establishment of a caliphate, Islamist terrorist groups view suicide attacks as one of their most effective tactics. These groups utilize suicide bombings because they are seen as ‘a weapon system that can deliver ordnance reliably and with precision’ (Lewis 2007, 224). Such weapon systems are efficient, inexpensive, easy to organize, and extremely difficult to counter, while delivering maximum damage at a minimal cost. Suicide attacks enable religious fundamentalist terrorist groups to destabilize the government of nationalist leaders, increasing their chances of success by converting human beings into guidance systems to target those leaders who have kidnapped, murdered, and otherwise persecuted religious minorities. Furthermore, glorifying martyrdom enhances the appeal of these groups and encourages more sympathetic individuals to join them, further strengthening their legitimacy (Benmelech, Berrebi, and Klor 2012).

There are certain countries, such as Nigeria, Somalia, and Myanmar, where we can observe a connection between nationalism and terrorism. However, Boko Haram, a group in Nigeria, emerged primarily due to economic inequality rather than religious persecution. Al-Shabaab, based in Somalia, gained notoriety as an

armed resistance movement against Ethiopian occupation during the Somali Civil War. In contrast, the Rohingya Solidarity Organization (RSO) in Myanmar exemplifies the link between nationalism and terrorism. In Nigeria and Somalia, it is challenging to connect nationalism to terrorism, as there have been few leaders with a strong sense of nationalism throughout their histories, except during the early independence periods. Meanwhile, Myanmar is a clear case for this connection, as numerous nationalist leaders have significantly influenced its political landscape.

The Rohingya Solidarity Organization (RSO) was established in response to widespread military violence against Rohingya Muslims in Myanmar. Founded in 1982, the RSO remains active today. For instance, nationalist leader Ne Win attempted to suppress Islam, the dominant faith among the Rohingya, under the guise of protecting Theravada Buddhism, the country's official religion. Ne Win's nationalist agenda backfired, leading to a series of terrorist attacks, many of which were carried out by the RSO. In 1978, Ne Win initiated a large-scale military campaign called Operation Dragon King, aiming to expel what he termed 'foreign believers' – referring to the Rohingya. Subsequently, the Citizenship Law enacted by the People's Assembly (then the Burmese legislature) in 1982 granted citizenship based on nationality but excluded the Rohingya from the 135 officially recognized ethnoreligious groups. This legal exclusion resulted in the Rohingya being stripped of their rights regarding property, marriage, travel, education, and employment. By falsely portraying Rohingya Muslims as illegal immigrants in his predominantly Buddhist country, Ne Win displayed indifference – or even complicity – toward the regular pogroms against them (Holliday 2010). In reaction, Rohingya Muslims organized to address their collective interests by founding the RSO in the early 1980s. Since then, the RSO has continued to respond to Buddhist nationalist leaders by recruiting new members and carrying out numerous terrorist attacks. For example, on 28 April 1994, the RSO planted and detonated nine out of 12 bombs in various locations in Maungdaw, damaging a fire engine and several buildings, and seriously injuring four civilians (Rafi 2017).

The nationalist politics of Myanmar's Buddhist leaders are likely to persist in the foreseeable future. In the national elections of 2015 and the by-elections of 2017 and 2018, neither the ruling party nor the main opposition party supported any Muslim candidates, resulting in no Muslim representation in parliament. Buddhists comprise the vast majority of parliamentarians today, while Muslims remain absent.⁹ The current de facto head of government, Min Aung Hlaing, who overthrew the democratic government of former State Counsellor Aung San Suu Kyi in 2021, has re-imposed martial law and military rule. He is known for targeting Rohingya Muslims, leading to genocide, crimes against humanity, and war crimes (Farmaner 2017). It is not surprising that Min Aung Hlaing's nationalist agenda has intensified the terrorist activities of the RSO, which carried out an attack on a military camp on 30 March 2021 (Alam 2021). This situation exemplifies how resilient the violent conflict can be between nationalist leaders and religious fundamentalist terrorist groups.

The discussion above leads to the following hypothesis:

H4: Nationalist leaders are positively associated with the activities of religious fundamentalist terrorist groups whose beliefs are discriminated against.

Research design

To empirically test the four hypotheses related to nationalism, I employ a sample of 726 terrorist groups across 100 countries during the period from 1970 to 2016. Since the theoretical discussion centers on how terrorist groups respond to the nationalist politics of state leaders, the unit of analysis is the terrorist group-year.

Dependent variable

The dependent variable is the activity of each terrorist group, which is challenging to identify (Young 2019). I construct four terrorist groups: ethnonationalist, left-wing, right-wing, and religious fundamentalist. Note that some groups may have mixed political ideologies and motivations. The Taliban and the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS), for example, pursue both ethnonationalist and religious goals. However, for this study, they are classified as religious groups since their dominant ideology is religious fundamentalism. This classification scheme, which is based on one dominant ideology, is standard in the literature, as in Brockhoff, Krieger, and Meierrieks (2016), Hou, Gaibullov, and Sandler (2020), and S. Jones and Libicki (2008). The classification scheme ‘gives a more orderly field to study [the root causes of modern terrorism] (admittedly an advantage)’ (Cronin [2002] 2003, 39) and thus enabled me to identify the general trend in each of the four terrorist groups.

Specifically, I follow the classification scheme of Extended Data on Terrorist Groups (EDTG) compiled by Hou, Gaibullov, and Sandler (2020).¹⁰ Since EDTG is an updated version of Blomberg, Gaibullov, and Sandler (2011) and Gaibullov and Sandler (2019), it is the most up-to-date dataset on the four types of terrorist groups. It is worth noting that EDTG does not include criminal or drug trafficking groups (Hou 2021).

I create two sets of four dependent variables. In the first set, I measure each dependent variable, the activity of each terrorist group, as the total number of terrorist attacks that the group engaged in a given year. Since the dependent variable is counts and its variance is not much larger than the mean, I use Poisson regression as the estimation method with robust standard errors.¹¹ I specify robust standard errors that are robust to some kinds of misspecification.

In the second set, I operationalize the activity of each terrorist group by evaluating whether the group was in operation in a given year. Each group variable is dichotomous, coded as ‘1’ when I observed any terrorist incident in a given group per year and ‘0’ otherwise. I use the U.K. to illustrate how I operationalize the activity of four types of terrorist groups in that country. I identified 332 activities involving 17 different terrorist groups during the sample period. I assigned ‘1’ for 209 activities related to 10 ethnonationalist terrorist groups (e.g. the Irish Volunteers received 47 ones since the group was operational for 47 years from 1970 to 2016) and ‘0’ otherwise; ‘1’ for 102 activities by four left-wing terrorist groups (e.g. the Earth Liberation Front committed 25 acts of terrorism for 1992-2016) and ‘0’ otherwise; ‘1’ for 16 activities by two right-wing terrorist groups (e.g. the English Defense League engaged in 8 times for 2009-2016) and ‘0’ otherwise; ‘1’ for five activities by one religious fundamentalist terrorist group (e.g. the Abu Hafs al-Masri Brigades, for 2003-2007) and ‘0’ otherwise.

Among 726 terrorist groups collected over the past four decades,¹² I found 296 ethnonationalist terrorist groups (41 percent), 192 left-wing terrorist groups (26 percent), 35 right-wing terrorist groups (5 percent), and 203 religious fundamentalist terrorist groups (28 percent). Given its high frequency, the activity of a given terrorist group is not a rare event.

My approach of not classifying terrorist groups into domestic versus transnational entities is consistent with Hou, Gaibullov, and Sandler's (2020, 202 and 211): 'Most terrorist groups engage in both domestic and transnational terrorist events,' and 'for any ideology or period ... terrorist group data sets must include domestic terrorist attacks.' It is, however, worth noting that 'domestic terrorist attacks far outnumber transnational terrorist attacks' (Hou, Gaibullov, and Sandler 2020, 202; see also Choi 2025).

Since the dependent variables in the second set are dichotomous, I use logistic regression as the estimation method with robust standard errors. Consistent with Hou, Gaibullov, and Sandler's (2020) method, I implement robust standard errors that allow me to obtain unbiased standard errors of logit coefficients under heteroscedasticity.¹³

Since some years are more prone to terrorism, I control for temporal effects.¹⁴ This is consistent with Rapoport's (2004) argument that terrorism occurs in historical waves worldwide. I also incorporated region fixed-effects since waves of terrorism tend to occur in regions, not individual countries, indicating the necessity of controlling for regions over countries.¹⁵ I use seven regional dummy variables to control for the geographic location of the base country: Eastern Asia and the Pacific, Europe and Central Asia, Latin America and the Caribbean, Middle East and North Africa, North America, South Asia, and sub-Saharan Africa. The Middle East and North Africa region is the reference in the model.

Independent variable

The main independent variable, state leaders' nationalism, poses challenges to measure. Although a few case studies explore the relationship between nationalism and terrorist groups, it has not yet been put to the statistical test because 'nationalism is hard to measure in a way that facilitates cross-country comparisons over time' (O'Leary and Sambanis 2018, 420). However, the 2019 Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) Project has a silver lining since it compiles nationalism data across countries and across time.¹⁶ Notably, Choi (2022, 2023), Ko Choi (2022), Ko and Shin (2021), and Mansfield and Pevehouse (2022) are five of the most recent examples that utilized the V-Dem Project's nationalism variable to operationalize the nationalist politics of state leaders. The V-Dem Project recruited at least five specialists per country to survey and cross-check the nationalist orientation of state leaders with the following instructions: 'Governments make legitimacy claims – provide justifications for the form of rule under which they govern. In the following section, we are interested in the nature of the legitimacy claims made by the sitting government. Please note that the government's claims to legitimacy – their legitimization strategies – are the object of inquiry here' (V-Dem Codebook V.10 2020, 208).

The V-Dem Project designed two survey questions to assess the degree of nationalism. The first question is, 'To what extent does the current government¹⁷ promote a specific

ideology or societal model (an officially codified set of beliefs used to justify a particular set of social, political, and economic relations) in order to justify the regime in place?' The second question is, 'How would you characterize the ideology/ideologies identified in the previous question?' With these two questions, the V-Dem Project was able to evaluate how actively leaders legitimize their political power through nationalism across countries and across time. Drawing on the point estimates from a Bayesian latent factor model, the V-Dem Project converted the survey results into a continuous index of nationalism on a scale of '0' (lowest) to '1' (highest).¹⁸

Given the specific instructions for the two survey questions, the measure does not capture whether state leaders turn more nationalistic leading up to conflict or in the middle of a crisis. The V-Dem Project assigns a consistent score to each leader's regime, so it does not bump it up before the outbreak of a specific conflict. For instance, the nationalism score for Donald Trump was consistently highest, recorded as '1' during his four-year tenure in office. When Jaafar Nimeiry ruled Sudan from 1971 to 1985, his score was 0.8. His score did not increase before the Second Sudanese Civil War broke out in 1983.

Since the V-Dem measure does not capture the origins of nationalism, but simply its presence, reverse causality is not an issue.

Control variables

To avoid spurious results, I include several control variables that have been commonly demonstrated to have some relation to terrorist events: income inequality, economic development, education, democracy, democracy squared, ethnic diversity, ethnic diversity squared, international conflict, internal conflict, elevation, land territory in the tropics, and landlocked.¹⁹

Poor economic conditions may foster a favorable environment for terrorism. When the national economy improves, it reduces economic grievances and thus minimizes terrorist activity (Boylan 2016; Choi 2014, 2015, 2018, 2019; Choi and Luo 2013; Li 2005; for a dissenting view, see; Freytag et al. 2011; Piazza 2006). I operationalize poor economic conditions in two ways: income inequality and economic development. Income inequality captures the unequal distribution of income and opportunity between different social groups. It is measured using the Gini coefficient using UNU-WIDER's (2017) World Income Inequality Database (WIID3.4).²⁰ Economic development creates winners and losers, widening feelings of relative deprivation. It is operationalized as the logarithm of real gross domestic product per capita in constant 2010 US dollars, and data is gathered from the World Bank's (2018) WDI data set.

Education may influence the activity of terrorist groups. Poorly educated people may join terrorist groups as foot soldiers more frequently than highly educated people. In comparison, highly educated people may organize terrorist groups and adopt leadership roles more often than poorly educated individuals since they have exceptional knowledge, experience, or skills (Benmelech, Berrebi, and Klor 2012; Bueno de Mesquita 2005). I operationalize education as the average years of education among citizens older than 15 with data collected from Clio Infra.²¹

Political factors such as democracy and ethnic diversity may encourage or discourage terrorist violence. For example, disgruntled people in democracies tend to pursue

a peaceful resolution of conflicts. Moreover, democratic institutions are likely to reduce the likelihood of terrorist violence (Choi 2010). However, democratic political institutions may also provide advantages for terrorist groups, such as the freedom of association to easily organize their activity and the freedom of expression to disseminate their messages quickly (Li 2005).

Furthermore, the impact of democracy on terrorism may not be straightforward. While democracy can initially reduce the activity of terrorist groups, it may become detrimental once a certain threshold is reached. When a regime imposes limits on the executive branch, terrorism could become more common. Conversely, if a regime permits the representation of all viewpoints, this can help manage grievances and decrease terrorism. Regimes prioritizing their constituents' safety and well-being are also more likely to take measures to prevent attacks (Choi 2018). Gaibullov, Piazza, and Sandler (2017) propose a coherent theory about a nonlinear, inverted U-shaped relationship between democracy and the square of democracy. They are the first to use both democracy and its squared term as robust independent variables to analyze the factors influencing terrorist attacks (see also Gaibullov and Sandler 2021). Following the approach of Gaibullov, Piazza, and Sandler (2017), I include both democracy and democracy squared in the same model. These variables are operationalized using the Polity IV data set (Marshall and Jaggers 2017).

Countries with a high level of ethnic diversity may experience more incidents of terrorism until they reach a certain threshold, after which the frequency of such incidents decreases (Choi and Piazza 2016a). Reilly ([2000] 2001) posits that neither very low nor very high levels of ethnic diversity contribute to ethnic conflict because strategies of monoethnic hegemony make less sense. In contrast, moderate levels of ethnic fragmentation are more likely to encourage the politicization of ethnic divides (see also Jensen and Skaaning 2011). To analyze this, I have created an index that measures ethnic diversity and its squared value, utilizing data from Alesina et al. (2003).

Security factors such as international and internal conflict may affect acts of terrorism. Whether international or internal, an unstable security environment should lead to the rise of terrorist groups. Conflict-affected countries are too weak to deploy sufficient security forces, so they cannot establish order over undisputed areas (Choi and Piazza 2016b, 2017; Hegre and Sambanis 2006; Piazza and Choi 2018). International and internal conflict are dichotomous, coded as '1' for each event and '0' otherwise. The data comes from Brecke's (2001) Conflict Catalog.

To account for the effects of geographical features, I include the logarithm of a country's average elevation, the percentage share of land territory in the tropics, and a dummy variable equal to '1' if a base country is landlocked (Central Intelligence Agency 2018; Gallup, Mellinger, and Sachs 1999; Gallup, Sachs, and Mellinger 1999). Higher elevation and tropics and landlocked countries may contribute to terrorist groups' survival by giving them more secure sanctuaries.

Table 1 displays the summary of the descriptive statistics.

Empirical results

Table 2 displays the results of simple logistic regression models. The overall results in the table indicate that the impact of nationalist leaders varies depending on the political

Table 1. Descriptive statistics.

Variable	Obs	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max
Nationalist Terrorist Group	9,098	0.466	0.499	0	1
Left Wing Terrorist Group	9,098	0.244	0.429	0	1
Right Wing Terrorist Group	9,098	0.029	0.169	0	1
Religious Fundamentalist Terrorist Group	9,098	0.261	0.439	0	1
Nationalism	9,098	0.582	0.258	0	1
Income Inequality	7,004	38.393	7.929	20.100	69.500
Economic Development	8,573	7.998	1.507	5.098	11.236
Education	7,462	5.947	3.080	0.171	13.482
Democracy	8,854	13.592	6.041	0	20
Democracy ²	8,854	221.244	139.259	0	400
Ethnic Diversity	9,037	0.449	0.222	0.012	0.902
Ethnic Diversity ²	9,037	0.251	0.209	0.000	0.814
International Conflict	7,094	0.085	0.279	0	1
Internal Conflict	7,151	0.262	0.440	0	1
Elevation	9,065	6.387	0.631	3.405	7.850
Land Territory in the Tropics	9,065	0.378	0.417	0	1
Landlocked	9,098	0.070	0.256	0	1
Eastern Asia and Pacific	9,098	0.133	0.340	0	1
Europe and Central Asia	9,098	0.181	0.385	0	1
Latin America and Caribbean	9,098	0.085	0.279	0	1
Middle East and North Africa	9,098	0.218	0.413	0	1
North America	9,098	0.035	0.183	0	1
South Asia	9,098	0.295	0.456	0	1
Sub-Saharan Africa	9,098	0.133	0.340	0	1

Table 2. Nationalism and four types of terrorist groups: simple logistic models.

	Nationalist Model 1	Left Wing Model 2	Right Wing Model 3	Religious Fundamentalist Model 4
Nationalism	0.232** (0.081)	-2.310*** (0.098)	0.015 (0.254)	1.823*** (0.107)
Constant	-0.273*** (0.052)	0.124* (0.058)	-3.508*** (0.160)	-2.151*** (0.073)
Wald Chi ²	8.24	559.19	0.00	292.61
Prob > Chi ²	0.004	0.001	0.952	0.001
Pseudo R ²	0.001	0.053	0.000	0.035
Observations	9,098	9,098	9,098	9,098

Robust standard errors are in parentheses. * is 0.05, ** is 0.01, and *** is 0.001, two-tailed tests.

ideology of terrorist groups. The nationalist politics of state leaders appears to be a strong and positive predictor of the activity of terrorist groups that seek to address their ethnonationalist and religious grievances. These findings are not surprising given that these two types of terrorist groups typically have strong support within the population of the affected ethnic and religious groups (e.g. the Provisional Irish Republican Army and the Free Papua Movement), which are the primary victims of nationalist leaders. These results also confirm Richardson's (2006, 31) well-thought-out study in which he maintains that 'groups that have a strong base of support within the community can last indefinitely.'

In Model 1, the variable, *Nationalism*, is significant and positive. This is consistent with the first hypothesis: as nationalist leaders marginalize and antagonize ethnic others, ethnonationalist terrorist groups are more likely to pursue their objectives. In Model 2, *Nationalism* achieves significance with a negative sign, as hypothesized. It appears that left-wing terrorist groups are less likely to be activated in response to the nationalist

rhetoric and policies of state leaders. Since nationalism and Marxism-Leninism offer two diverging motivations for action, state leaders and left-wingers are unlikely to appeal to each other, going in opposite directions (Kis-Katos, Liebert, and Schulze 2014). The negative relationship may also be caused by the unpopularity of left-wing terrorist groups, which has drastically decreased since the collapse of the former Soviet Union. Upon witnessing the demise of Marxism-Leninism in December 1991, factory workers and farmers were disheartened by left-wing terrorist groups, so they may no longer consider them as a legitimate outlet to redress their economic grievances.

In Model 3, *Nationalism* has no statistical significance – nationalist leaders lead to neither an increase nor a decrease in the activity of right-wing terrorist groups. This result does not support the third hypothesis, though the coefficient sign is positive. Right-wing terrorist groups appear not to uphold the mandate on the preservation of their own race, which is often what nationalist leaders seek to accomplish by appealing to the dominant race. Theoretically, it may be that most right-wing terrorist groups come and go too quickly to make waves. As pointed out by Cronin [2002] 2003, 40), ‘In their most recent manifestations, [right-wing terrorists] have tended to be less cohesive and more impetuous in their violence than leftist terrorist groups.’ Empirically, the null result may come from the measurement of right-wing terrorist groups that does not separate racist groups from other right-wingers such as skinheads attacking immigrants and homosexuals. These theoretical and empirical factors may dilute the impact of nationalist leaders on right-wing terrorist groups – their effect is not discernible in the statistical estimation.

Consistent with the fourth hypothesis, *Nationalism* is significantly and positively associated with religious fundamentalist terrorist groups in Model 4. Since leaders’ nationalist rhetoric tends to have hostile overtones against non-official religions, the increased activity of religious fundamentalist terrorist groups is not surprising.

Table A1 displays another test of the effect of nationalist leaders on each terrorist group. Here, I operationalize the terrorist activity as the total number of terrorist attacks that each group initiated in a given year. The results of Poisson regression closely resemble those of the logistic regression shown in Table 2 – the influence of nationalist leaders varies, depending on the political ideology of terrorist groups.

To avoid arriving at spurious relationships between *Nationalism* and each terrorist group, I control for other factors that may affect both variables. Control variables holding political, economic, and social factors fixed are likely to improve the accuracy of how much *Nationalism* predicts the variation in the outcome variable. Table 3 shows the results of multivariate logistic regression models. Table 3 uses fewer observations than Table 2 due to data availability for the control variables. However, as far as the significance and sign of *Nationalism* are concerned, the overall results in Table 3 are identical to those in Table 2. The fact that the main findings of this study remain the same regardless of the sample size elevates the reliability and validity of the estimated results. Indeed, the findings of Table 3 also indicate that, depending on the group ideology, nationalist leaders are associated with some forms of terrorist groups, but not all. *Nationalism* is positively related to ethnonationalist and religious fundamentalist terrorist groups (Models 5 and 8); negatively associated with left-wing terrorist groups (Model 6); and not related to right-wing terrorist groups (Model 7).

Among the control variables,²² *Income Inequality* achieves significance across the board. However, the effect is mixed. When wealth is unequally distributed, it is less likely

Table 3. Nationalism and four types of terrorist groups: multivariate logistic models.

	Nationalist Model 5	Left Wing Model 6	Right Wing Model 7	Religious Fundamentalist Model 8
Nationalism	0.585*** (0.178)	-2.878*** (0.251)	0.007 (0.730)	1.289*** (0.179)
Income Inequality	-0.019** (0.006)	0.019** (0.007)	0.039* (0.018)	-0.018** (0.007)
Economic Development	-0.584*** (0.064)	0.189* (0.080)	1.009*** (0.217)	0.007 (0.064)
Education	0.253*** (0.027)	-0.289*** (0.033)	0.092 (0.056)	-0.149*** (0.024)
Democracy	-0.117*** (0.031)	-0.357*** (0.044)	-0.092 (0.133)	0.447*** (0.036)
Democracy ²	0.004** (0.001)	0.018*** (0.002)	0.008 (0.005)	-0.019*** (0.001)
Ethnic Diversity	14.610*** (1.042)	-14.178*** (1.022)	-3.672 (1.964)	-1.881* (0.850)
Ethnic Diversity ²	-17.489*** (1.100)	15.828*** (1.102)	7.067** (2.594)	2.818** (0.870)
International Conflict	0.261* (0.116)	-0.223 (0.163)	-0.612 (0.357)	-0.227 (0.124)
Internal Conflict	0.066 (0.079)	0.312** (0.100)	-1.292*** (0.326)	-0.426*** (0.091)
Elevation	-1.319*** (0.109)	1.013*** (0.106)	-0.080 (0.210)	0.057 (0.083)
Land Territory in the Tropics	-1.689*** (0.203)	1.099*** (0.239)	-0.564 (0.440)	-1.241*** (0.152)
Landlocked	0.982*** (0.220)	1.248*** (0.210)	dropped	-2.122*** (0.326)
Eastern Asia and Pacific	0.832*** (0.156)	0.767*** (0.188)	-0.977* (0.477)	0.443*** (0.117)
Europe and Central Asia	0.713*** (0.131)	1.564*** (0.164)	-1.150*** (0.272)	-1.081*** (0.129)
Latin America and Caribbean	-2.222*** (0.355)	4.500*** (0.286)	0.902* (0.385)	dropped
North America	-2.841*** (0.281)	2.863*** (0.230)	0.779*** (0.227)	0.349 (0.208)
South Asia	1.059*** (0.147)	-0.171 (0.217)	1.661** (0.568)	-0.576*** (0.157)
Sub-Saharan Africa	4.182*** (0.328)	-1.329*** (0.324)	1.142 (0.688)	-0.920*** (0.218)
Constant	9.753*** (0.854)	-4.684*** (0.968)	-14.927*** (2.222)	-1.672* (0.789)
Wald Chi ²	652.08	900.55	567.80	946.47
Prob > Chi ²	0.001	0.001	0.001	0.001
Pseudo R ²	0.227	0.386	0.278	0.147
Observations	6,058	6,058	6,058	6,058

Robust standard errors are in parentheses. * is 0.05, ** is 0.01, and *** is 0.001, two-tailed tests.

to see the activity of either ethnonationalist or religious fundamentalist terrorist groups, but it is more likely to see the rise of either left or right-wing terrorist groups. Table 3 also controls for regional differences. Compared to the Middle East and North Africa, two regions (Eastern Asia and the Pacific, and Europe and Central Asia) garner some statistical significance across the four models, even though their effects are mixed and depend on the ideology of terrorist groups. Including region dummies is necessary because some regions are more prone to terrorism than others.

Table 4 is a percentage table, displaying substantive effects – the change in probability when the predictor or independent variable increases by one unit. For binary variables such as International Conflict and Internal Conflict, the change is

Table 4. Nationalism and four types of terrorist groups: average percent change.

	Nationalist Model 5	Left Wing Model 6	Right Wing Model 7	Religious Fundamentalist Model 8
Nationalism	0.134*** (0.0407)	−0.500*** (0.0432)	5.87e-05 (0.00631)	0.191*** (0.0267)
Income Inequality	−0.00442*** (0.00140)	0.00323*** (0.00121)	0.000337** (0.000149)	−0.00270*** (0.000962)
Economic Development	−0.134*** (0.0146)	0.0328** (0.0139)	0.00873*** (0.00172)	0.00106 (0.00946)
Education	0.0582*** (0.00642)	−0.0503*** (0.00569)	0.000797 (0.000514)	−0.0220*** (0.00354)
Democracy	−0.0269*** (0.00713)	−0.0620*** (0.00724)	−0.000792 (0.00121)	0.0662*** (0.00510)
Democracy ²	0.000941*** (0.000312)	0.00317*** (0.000323)	7.10e-05 (4.93e-05)	−0.00282*** (0.000210)
Ethnic Diversity	3.360*** (0.229)	−2.463*** (0.181)	−0.0318* (0.0163)	−0.278** (0.126)
Ethnic Diversity ²	−4.022*** (0.242)	2.750*** (0.196)	0.0611*** (0.0205)	0.417*** (0.128)
International Conflict	0.0599** (0.0267)	−0.0387 (0.0282)	−0.00529 (0.00324)	−0.0336* (0.0184)
Internal Conflict	0.0151 (0.0182)	0.0541*** (0.0176)	−0.0112*** (0.00310)	−0.0631*** (0.0132)
Elevation	−0.303*** (0.0227)	0.176*** (0.0190)	−0.000691 (0.00181)	0.00837 (0.0123)
Land Territory in the Tropics	−0.389*** (0.0457)	0.191*** (0.0421)	−0.00488 (0.00376)	−0.184*** (0.0222)
Landlocked	0.226*** (0.0495)	0.217*** (0.0358)	dropped	−0.314*** (0.0477)
Eastern Asia and Pacific	0.191*** (0.0354)	0.133*** (0.0323)	−0.00845** (0.00383)	0.0656*** (0.0176)
Europe and Central Asia	0.164*** (0.0299)	0.272*** (0.0281)	−0.00995*** (0.00251)	−0.160*** (0.0189)
Latin America and Caribbean	−0.511*** (0.0764)	0.782*** (0.0526)	0.00781** (0.00389)	dropped
North America	−0.653*** (0.0636)	0.497*** (0.0395)	0.00674*** (0.00244)	0.0517* (0.0308)
South Asia	0.244*** (0.0338)	−0.0298 (0.0377)	0.0144*** (0.00476)	−0.0853*** (0.0229)
Sub-Saharan Africa	0.962*** (0.0744)	−0.231*** (0.0570)	0.00988 (0.00646)	−0.136*** (0.0319)
Observations	6,058	6,058	6,058	6,058

Robust standard errors are in parentheses. * is 0.05, ** is 0.01, and *** is 0.001, two-tailed tests.

from 0 to 1, so one ‘unit’ is as it is usually thought. For continuous variables such as Nationalism, this represents the instantaneous change, given that the ‘unit’ may be very small. The table indicates that ethnonationalist and religious fundamentalist terrorist groups are more likely to gain strength under nationalist leaders, while left-wing terrorist groups, whose marginal effect is largest, experience a downturn. The analysis of substantive effects confirms the results of the conventional significance level tests.

It also may be that some specific years are more prone to terrorism than others, since terrorism occurs in waves (Rapoport 2004). To account for temporal effects, I control for each year. The results, reported in Table A3, coincide with the study’s main findings in Table 3.²³

Conclusion

Researchers studying nationalism and terrorism have often overlooked the impact of nationalist leaders on driving terrorist groups, despite their significant influence on various terrorist events. This study aims to bridge the gap between the literature on nationalism and terrorism by arguing that when nationalist leaders target a specific population, they activate particular types of terrorist groups. This perspective differs from previous analyses, which have focused on ethnic leaders as being responsible for all types of terrorist attacks.²⁴ Specifically, this research links nationalist state leaders, not ethnic leaders, to specific types of terrorist organizations. Evidence suggests that nationalist leaders are positively associated with ethnonationalist and religious fundamentalist terrorist groups, while their influence negatively impacts left-wing terrorist groups, and has little to no effect on right-wing terrorist groups.

Most earlier studies have treated all terrorist groups as equal, assuming they operate under the same political ideology. This treatment has hindered a proper understanding of the relationship between nationalism and terrorism, leading to misleading policy recommendations. Although a more systematic empirical examination may be necessary, this study offers important policy insights. The divisive politics embraced by some state leaders can undermine nation-building efforts, destabilizing the political order and inciting activity from ethnonationalist or religious fundamentalist terrorist groups. This environment may increase volatility as state leaders adopt ‘us’ versus ‘them’ narratives to enhance their popularity and legitimacy.

State leaders who rely on nationalism for legitimacy often struggle to create a peaceful and diverse society. Instead, they may make their nations more vulnerable to terrorist attacks, contrasting with their expected role in leading the fight against terrorism. This presents a significant challenge for the counter-terrorism community, which must devise effective strategies independently of national leaders’ support. This analysis makes it crucial to elect political leaders who do not adhere to nationalistic ideologies. However, there is some positive news: nationalist state leaders are generally unlikely to support either left-wing or right-wing terrorist groups.²⁵

Notes

1. Auger (2020), for example, shows that Donald Trump’s rhetoric of ‘the Hispanic invasion of Texas’ provoked a white terrorist to attack a Walmart in El Paso, Texas.
2. I follow Hou, Gaibullov, and Sandler’s (2020, 201) definition of a terrorist group – ‘a subnational collective whose members try to obtain a political goal by intimidating an audience (or constituency) through violence or its threat.’
3. Notable exceptions include Choi (2022) and Klein (2021).
4. As popularized by LaFree and Dugan (2007, 184), I view terrorism as ‘the threatened or actual use of illegal force and violence to attain a political, economic, religious or social goal through fear, coercion or intimidation’ (see also LaFree and Ackerman 2009).
5. See <https://www.whitehouse.gov/briefing-room/statements-releases/2021/06/15/fact-sheet-national-strategy-for-counteracting-domestic-terrorism/>.
6. I do not discuss other types of nationalism, such as civic nationalism, mainly due to data unavailability across countries and across years.

Non-nationalist leaders gain legitimacy by winning votes from multiple ethnic groups and emphasize cooperation and compromise rather than division. An example

of a non-nationalist leader is Josip Broz Tito, who sought to maintain unity in Yugoslavia despite its diverse nationalities, languages, and religions. In contrast, Slobodan Milošević was a nationalist leader who strengthened his regime by promoting the idea of a 'Greater Serbia,' which advocates for the establishment of a Serbian state that includes regions of historical significance to Serbs, even those outside present-day Serbia (Gagnon 2006). In the United States, Barack Obama is viewed as a non-nationalist leader, while Donald Trump is considered a nationalist (Segarra 2017).

7. Nationalism is related to populism, focusing on average people's politico-economic concerns. However, 'populism is a national political movement in [about 30] democratic societies' in recent years (K. Jones 2021, 4), so it is not comparable to my analysis of both democratic and non-democratic leaders.
8. This section focuses on the political struggle between nationalist leaders and left-wing groups, not the conflicts between different types of terrorist groups such as left-wing and right-wing groups.
9. See the 2019 Report on International Religious Freedom: Burma at <https://www.state.gov/reports/2019-report-on-international-religious-freedom/burma/>.
10. For a more detailed explanation of the group classification, see <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/suppl/10.1177/0022002719857145>.
11. Negative binomial regression fails to converge since it is not a suitable estimator for the data with no large variance.
12. I exclude terrorist groups that are active in several countries when the Correlates of War Project does not provide country codes (see <https://correlatesofwar.org/data-sets>).
13. The results are similar when I allow for intragroup correlation and estimate robust standard errors.
14. Adding year fixed-effects is the simplest way to account for temporal effects. This assesses whether the passing of time per se affects the activity of terrorist groups or not. Another way is to use discrete time periods, such as decades, since some decades may experience more terrorist groups than others. Another way is to separate a sample data into two time periods: pre- versus post-9/11. Another solution is to include cubic polynomials of the time that account for potentially nonlinear trends in the birth of terrorist groups. Since the last three methods do not meaningfully alter the main findings of this study, I do not report the estimates to save space.
15. Empirically, country fixed-effects are problematic for my sample data; there is slight variation between the outcome variable and many country dummies, resulting in perfect collinearity (for a detailed discussion, see Beck and Katz 2001). When I employ linear probability models (LPMs) that can bypass the collinearity issue, I discover that the main findings of this study remain the same. I do not report the estimated results of this study because showing predicted probabilities that cannot exist (i.e. they are above 1 or below 0) is not beneficial for the reader (Greene 2003).
16. The V-Dem Codebook V.10 provides detailed information (see <https://www.v-dem.net/en/>).
17. The government includes the chief executive, the cabinet, ministries, and top civil servants (V-Dem Codebook V.10, 208).
18. I experimented with different time lags of the nationalist leaders' variable and found its statistical significance in up to three lagged terms.
19. The inclusion of those controls is analogous to Hou, Gaibullov, and Sandler (2020) and Gaibullov and Sandler (2013, 2014). Other control variables, such as group size and state capacity, are not discussed because their effects are widely reported in previous studies and because their inclusion does not alter the main findings of this study.
20. See <https://www.wider.unu.edu/database/world-income-inequality-database-wiid34>.
21. See <https://clio-infra.eu/>.
22. Including the squared terms, Democracy² and Ethnic Diversity², may complicate the estimation. To be safe, I re-run models without the squared terms. Table A2 reports the results, which do not deviate from those in Table 3.

23. Table A3 shows that two control variables (International Conflict in Models 2, 3, and 4 and North America in Model 4) become significant at the 0.05 level. This occurs because those models are controlled for temporal effects. It appears that when countries are involved in international conflict (dealing with outside enemies), they are less likely to experience terrorist activity instigated by left-wingers, right-wingers, and religious fundamentalists.
24. When previous studies look at different ideologies of terrorist groups, they tend to use them as predictors rather than the outcome variable. For example, Gaibullov, Hou, and Sandler (2020) skillfully show how different ideologies determine terrorist groups' success.
25. An exception to this empirical finding is the rise of anarchist militants and right-wing fraternal organizations (such as the Proud Boys), which coincided with the rise of Donald Trump.

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No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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Appendix

Table A1. Nationalism and four types of terrorist groups: simple poisson regression the dependent variable is the total number of terrorist attacks.

	Nationalist Model 1	Left Wing Model 2	Right Wing Model 3	Religious Fundamentalist Model 4
Nationalism	0.124** (0.043)	−1.655*** (0.063)	0.015 (0.246)	1.311*** (0.074)
Constant	−0.837*** (0.028)	−0.540*** (0.034)	−3.537*** (0.156)	−2.162*** (0.055)
Wald Chi ²	8.26	687.31	0.00	315.92
Prob > Chi ²	0.004	0.001	0.952	0.001
Pseudo R ²	0.001	0.037	0.00	0.024
Observations	9,098	9,098	9,098	9,098

Robust standard errors are in parentheses. * is 0.05, ** is 0.01, and *** is 0.001, two-tailed tests.

Table A2. Nationalism and four types of terrorist groups: without squared terms.

	Nationalist Model 5	Left Wing Model 6	Right Wing Model 7	Religious Fundamentalist Model 8
Nationalism	0.391* (0.160)	−2.833*** (0.218)	0.013 (0.674)	1.507*** (0.207)
Income Inequality	−0.009 (0.005)	0.009 (0.007)	0.027 (0.016)	−0.012 (0.006)
Economic Development	−0.466*** (0.059)	0.139 (0.072)	0.915*** (0.183)	0.144* (0.064)
Education	0.191*** (0.024)	−0.136*** (0.029)	0.114* (0.056)	−0.157*** (0.026)
Democracy	−0.031*** (0.008)	0.042*** (0.011)	0.121** (0.042)	0.022** (0.009)
Democracy ²	excluded	excluded	excluded	excluded
Ethnic Diversity	−0.972*** (0.268)	−0.899* (0.368)	1.702 (1.022)	1.037** (0.357)
Ethnic Diversity ²	excluded	excluded	excluded	excluded
International Conflict	0.445*** (0.114)	−0.331* (0.162)	−0.641 (0.369)	−0.415** (0.128)
Internal Conflict	0.270*** (0.075)	0.326*** (0.094)	−1.408*** (0.315)	−0.393*** (0.091)
Elevation	−0.970*** (0.089)	0.701*** (0.096)	−0.131 (0.207)	0.128 (0.091)
Land Territory in the Tropics	−0.456** (0.158)	0.337 (0.215)	−0.709 (0.432)	−1.208*** (0.165)
Landlocked	0.726*** (0.184)	1.214*** (0.236)	dropped	−1.933*** (0.325)
Eastern Asia and Pacific	0.004 (0.118)	0.814*** (0.160)	−0.584 (0.429)	0.656*** (0.119)

(Continued)

Table A2. (Continued).

	Nationalist Model 5	Left Wing Model 6	Right Wing Model 7	Religious Fundamentalist Model 8
Europe and Central Asia	0.269* (0.121)	1.362*** (0.141)	-0.931*** (0.249)	-1.156*** (0.137)
Latin America and Caribbean	-2.864*** (0.306)	4.386*** (0.252)	1.236*** (0.361)	dropped
North America	-2.091*** (0.269)	2.001*** (0.202)	0.837*** (0.214)	-0.470* (0.217)
South Asia	0.806*** (0.137)	-0.206 (0.179)	1.673** (0.546)	-0.355* (0.158)
Sub-Saharan Africa	1.093*** (0.178)	0.871*** (0.245)	2.339*** (0.480)	-0.324 (0.195)
Constant	9.282*** (0.796)	-6.015*** (0.863)	-15.426*** (1.733)	-2.685** (0.878)
Wald Chi ²				
Prob > Chi ²	0.001	0.001	0.001	0.001
Pseudo R ²	0.227	0.386	0.278	0.147
Observations	6,058	6,058	6,058	6,058

Robust standard errors are in parentheses. * is 0.05, ** is 0.01, and *** is 0.001, two-tailed tests.

Table A3. Nationalism and four types of terrorist groups: temporal effects controlled.

	Nationalist Model 1	Left Wing Model 2	Right Wing Model 3	Religious Fundamentalist Model 4
Nationalism	0.585* (0.238)	-2.878*** (0.322)	0.007 (0.704)	1.289*** (0.234)
Income Inequality	-0.019*** (0.006)	0.019*** (0.004)	0.039** (0.014)	-0.018*** (0.005)
Economic Development	-0.584*** (0.060)	0.189** (0.071)	1.009*** (0.172)	0.007 (0.052)
Education	0.253*** (0.029)	-0.289*** (0.025)	0.092* (0.039)	-0.149*** (0.018)
Democracy	-0.117*** (0.025)	-0.357*** (0.034)	-0.092 (0.152)	0.447*** (0.033)
Democracy ²	0.004*** (0.001)	0.018*** (0.001)	0.008 (0.006)	-0.019*** (0.001)
Ethnic Diversity	14.610*** (0.881)	-14.178*** (0.585)	-3.672* (1.586)	-1.881** (0.631)
Ethnic Diversity ²	-17.489*** (0.982)	15.828*** (0.617)	7.067** (2.362)	2.818*** (0.570)
International Conflict	0.261* (0.107)	-0.223* (0.087)	-0.612* (0.262)	-0.227* (0.111)
Internal Conflict	0.066 (0.074)	0.312*** (0.085)	-1.292*** (0.272)	-0.426*** (0.105)
Elevation	-1.319*** (0.111)	1.013*** (0.099)	-0.080 (0.196)	0.057 (0.094)

(Continued)

Table A3. (Continued).

	Nationalist Model 1	Left Wing Model 2	Right Wing Model 3	Religious Fundamentalist Model 4
Land Territory in the Tropics	−1.689*** (0.258)	1.099*** (0.192)	−0.564 (0.354)	−1.241*** (0.182)
Landlocked	0.982*** (0.239)	1.248*** (0.186)	dropped	−2.122*** (0.321)
Eastern Asia and Pacific	0.832*** (0.113)	0.767*** (0.091)	−0.977* (0.398)	0.443*** (0.098)
Europe and Central Asia	0.713*** (0.077)	1.564*** (0.162)	−1.150*** (0.229)	−1.081*** (0.138)
Latin America and Caribbean	−2.222*** (0.347)	4.500*** (0.299)	0.902** (0.337)	dropped
North America	−2.841*** (0.377)	2.863*** (0.149)	0.779*** (0.138)	0.349* (0.143)
South Asia	1.059*** (0.117)	−0.171 (0.213)	1.661*** (0.462)	−0.576** (0.188)
Sub-Saharan Africa	4.182*** (0.214)	−1.329*** (0.218)	1.142 (0.635)	−0.920*** (0.114)
Constant	9.753*** (0.825)	−4.684*** (0.807)	−14.927*** (1.876)	−1.672* (0.811)
Wald Chi ²	6656.94	5404.50	5614.63	6999.31
Prob > Chi ²	0.001	0.001	0.952	0.001
Pseudo R ²	0.227	0.386	0.278	0.147
Observations	6,058	6,058	6,058	6,058

Robust standard errors are in parentheses. * is 0.05, ** is 0.01, and *** is 0.001, two-tailed tests.